

Scrum Retrospective – Erasmus+ Traineeship Project

Introduction

At the end of my Erasmus+ traineeship preparation project, I completed a Scrum retrospective to review how I managed the project, what went well, what did not go well and what I would change in a future project. The project was divided into four sprints covering research, application preparation, interview and cultural preparation, and accommodation, travel and financial planning.

Although I completed the project successfully, I finished it **after the original submission deadline**. The main reasons were that I underestimated the amount of time the project would require, started the project later than I should have, and was trying to manage this project alongside **three other projects and my exams**. As a result, I had difficulty dividing my time effectively between all of my academic responsibilities.

What Went Well

One of the main things that went well was creating a **Product Backlog** before starting the main work. Breaking the project into individual backlog items made the large assignment easier to understand and gave me a clear list of tasks to complete.

The four-sprint structure also worked well. Each sprint had a specific purpose:

- **Sprint 1:** Internship research and selection
- **Sprint 2:** Application and portfolio preparation
- **Sprint 3:** Interview and cultural preparation
- **Sprint 4:** Accommodation, travel, financial planning and final report

This structure prevented me from trying to complete every part of the project at the same time. It also allowed me to gradually build the final report from the research and preparation completed during each sprint.

Another successful part was the **Definition of Done (DoD)**. The DoD gave me specific criteria for deciding whether a task was complete. For example, when researching internships, I needed to record the company, location, duration, requirements and suitability. This helped me avoid considering a task finished when only part of the work had been completed.

The research itself also went well. I identified three opportunities in Slovenia, Greece and Belgium and compared them based on their duration, technical requirements and relevance to my Software Development studies. I also researched accommodation, transport, cultural

differences and living costs. This gave me a more realistic understanding of what completing an Erasmus+ traineeship would involve.

What Did Not Go Well

The biggest problem was **time management**. I completed the project after the due date. I underestimated how much time would be required to complete the research, documentation and final report.

Another major factor was that I was managing this project alongside **three other academic projects and exams**. Having several deadlines and study requirements at the same time made it difficult to dedicate enough consistent time to the Erasmus+ project.

I also **started the project later than I should have**. Because I did not begin early enough, I had less time available to deal with unexpected delays. When some tasks took longer than expected, there was not enough spare time in my schedule to catch up.

Some of the research tasks were more time-consuming than I originally expected. For example, researching different internships, comparing their requirements and investigating accommodation, transport and living costs required more time than my original estimates suggested.

Another weakness was that I did not consistently record my **actual time spent** on every task. This made it difficult to compare my original estimates with the actual amount of work completed. If I had tracked this more carefully, I could have recognised earlier that I was falling behind.

What I Learned

The main lesson I learned is that **accurate time estimation and early planning are essential**, especially when managing multiple projects at the same time. Having a Product Backlog and sprint structure is useful, but they are only effective if I realistically consider how much time I actually have available.

I learned that I should consider my **entire academic workload** when planning a project. Instead of planning the Erasmus+ project as if it were my only responsibility, I should have considered the deadlines for my other three projects and my exams.

I also learned that I should start important projects earlier. Starting late created unnecessary pressure and reduced the amount of time available for reviewing and improving my work.

Another lesson was the importance of adding **buffer time** to estimates. If I believe a task will take two hours, I should allow additional time for unexpected research, technical problems or other responsibilities.

What I Would Change

If I were to complete the project again, I would start much earlier and create a more detailed schedule before Sprint 1. I would first look at all my academic deadlines, including my other three projects and exams, and then decide how much time I could realistically dedicate to this project each week.

I would also set an **internal deadline several days before the actual submission deadline**. This would give me time to proofread the report, check the Scrum evidence and correct any problems before submission.

I would record the actual time spent on every backlog item. At the end of each sprint, I would compare the estimated time with the actual time and adjust the remaining sprint plans accordingly.

I would also break larger tasks into smaller backlog items. For example, accommodation research could be divided into separate tasks for Maribor, Kavala and Geel. This would make it easier to see exactly what had been completed and what still needed attention.

Finally, I would conduct a short review at the end of every sprint. If I was falling behind, I could change my plan earlier rather than allowing the delay to continue until the end of the project.

Overall Reflection

Overall, Scrum was useful for managing my Erasmus+ traineeship preparation project. The Product Backlog helped me organise the work, the four sprints provided structure, and the Definitions of Done helped me understand what completion meant for each task.

However, the project also showed me that **Scrum cannot solve poor time management by itself**. I need to use the Scrum process properly by estimating realistically, tracking my actual progress and adapting my plan when circumstances change.

Finishing the project after the deadline was the main area I would improve. I take responsibility for this because I underestimated the workload and started later than I should have. At the same time, managing this project alongside three other projects and exams made the workload significantly more difficult to manage. This experience has taught me that future projects need to be planned around my complete workload rather than considered individually.

Despite the delay, I completed the planned research and produced the required project documentation. I identified three potential internship opportunities, researched the companies, prepared my CV and portfolio, investigated interview questions, researched cultural differences and considered accommodation, transport and living costs.

The most important improvement I will take from this project is to **start earlier, estimate time more realistically, track progress consistently and allow buffer time for other academic commitments**. These changes will help me manage future projects more effectively and improve my ability to meet deadlines while maintaining the quality of my work.